

CHAPTER

ONE

The Moment Everything Changed

The hallway was quieter than usual that morning, the kind of silence that makes every footstep sound too loud. Alex paused at the entrance, adjusting the strap of his bag and wondering, not for the first time, whether he was ready for what waited beyond the classroom door.

Nothing looked different. The same flickering fluorescent light hummed overhead, and the same faded posters curled slightly at the corners of the walls. Yet something felt off — as if the day had already decided to unfold in ways no one could predict.

He took a breath, pushed the door open, and stepped inside.

It would take years before Alex understood that moments rarely announce themselves when they matter most. At the time, it felt like any other Tuesday.